Listening for Engine Faults: Can a Pre-trained Audio Model Triage Fleet Vehicles?

Industry AI Challenge — Team 2 — DRAFT

Jeffrey Gregory and Jake Van Slyke

2026-11-10

Draft status. Numbers come from `notebooks/engine_fault_classification.ipynb`. Still open (**TODO**): listening to the misclassified clips. Every section should be rewritten in the team's own words.

1. Business problem

Client. The maintenance manager of a regional delivery fleet (~200 light vehicles) and the service writers who schedule shop time.

Problem. Engine faults such as *knock* (uncontrolled combustion that can damage pistons and bearings) and *misfire* (a cylinder failing to fire, which wastes fuel and can damage the catalytic converter) are expensive when caught late. Drivers notice "a weird noise" inconsistently, and technicians have limited time to triage complaints.

Current process. Drivers report problems verbally; a technician listens and runs an OBD-II scan. The engine computer flags many misfires with trouble codes, but intermittent or early problems may not set a code, and knock is often only heard. Without AI, the alternative is more frequent scheduled inspections.

What would make AI useful. A 10-second phone recording, taken during a routine pre-trip check, that flags vehicles likely to need an engine inspection. It needs no new hardware, and its job is to *prioritise* inspections, not replace the mechanic. There is commercial precedent: a used-car auction company reported about 21 % fewer engine-related buyer disputes while a sound-based fault detector, reviewed by humans, was switched on [8].

Cost of wrong predictions. A *missed fault* (false negative) lets a damaged engine keep running: possible engine or catalytic-converter repairs costing thousands, plus downtime. A *false alarm* (false positive) costs one unnecessary inspection (~30 min of technician time), and frequent false alarms erode trust in the tool. Missed faults are far more costly, so we prioritise recall while capping false alarms.

2. Model, data, and adaptation

Model. The Audio Spectrogram Transformer (AST, 86 M parameters) [1], fine-tuned by its authors on AudioSet [2], a 2-million-clip collection of labelled YouTube sounds that includes engine and vehicle categories. We chose it because it is a strong, widely used general-purpose audio model that runs from the Hugging Face `transformers` library and accepts our 16 kHz audio directly. **Alternative:** BEATs [3], a self-supervised audio model of similar size; for on-device use, a much smaller model such as YAMNet would be the reasonable option.

Dataset. KweriMoto Engine Sounds [4]: 1,067 mono 16 kHz clips (≤ 10 s) labelled `healthy` (351), `engine_knock` (608), or `misfire` (108), with predefined splits that keep every clip from a recording in one split — train 721, validation 154, test 154 — plus a separate `real_test` set of 38 real knocks. We verified there is no leakage between splits, including through the synthetic clips (see below).

Limitations relative to the business use. This dataset is not a fleet's recordings, and its structure creates a serious risk that a model learns *where a clip came from* instead of *what is wrong with the engine*:

- All misfire clips come from a single source; all AudioSet clips are knocks.
- Half of the knock clips are **synthetic** — an AudioSet knock sound mixed over a healthy car recording.

- `real_test` contains only knocks, so it cannot measure false alarms.
- No information about vehicle, microphone position, or engine speed; labels are not mechanic-confirmed.

Adaptation. (a) *Feature extraction:* AST is frozen and each clip becomes a 768-number summary; a linear classifier (2,307 parameters) is trained on top. (b) *Partial fine-tuning:* the top two AST layers are also trained.

3. Success criteria (set before training)

	Choice	Why
Model metric	**Fault recall**: average recall over knock and misfire	Missed faults are the costly error
Guardrail	**Healthy false-alarm rate**: share of healthy clips flagged	Too many false alarms → tool ignored
Business criterion	Catch ≥ **85 %** of faulty engines while flagging ≤ **20 %** of healthy ones	Useful as a triage aid
Operational constraint	**< 1 s per 10 s clip on a laptop CPU**	Runs on a shop PC or phone backend, no GPU

All model selection used the validation split; the test split is reserved for one final evaluation.

4. Experiments

We compared a majority-class benchmark, a baseline, and three experiments that each change one variable (Table 1). All runs use the same splits and selection rule (keep the epoch with the lowest validation loss).

Table 1: Validation results. Benchmark = always predict *knock* (the most common class).

Run	Change	Fault recall	False alarm	Knock (real)	Knock (synth.)	Misfire
Benchmark	Always predict majority class	0.50	1.00	1.00	1.00	0.00
Baseline	Frozen AST embeddings + linear head (lr 1e-3)	0.82	0.19	0.84	0.67	0.88
Exp 1	Unfreeze top 2 AST layers (fine-tune)	0.81	0.21	0.91	0.81	0.75
Exp 2	Inverse-frequency class weights	0.86	0.19	0.81	0.63	1.00
Exp 3	Drop synthetic knocks from training	0.78	0.15	0.93	0.42	0.88

Baseline (frozen AST + linear head). Fault recall 0.82 with a 0.19 false-alarm rate — far above the benchmark, but just short of the 85 % target. Validation loss is lowest at epoch 8 and rises afterwards (Figure 1): with only 721 training clips, even a linear head overfits quickly, so early stopping matters.

Experiment 1 — partial fine-tuning. *Expected:* adapting the top layers would help separate a knock from surrounding engine noise. *Happened:* knock recall improved (0.76 → 0.86), but misfire recall fell (0.88 → 0.75), so fault recall did not improve (Section 6).

Experiment 2 — class-weighted loss. *Expected:* weighting the rare misfire class (76 training clips) more heavily would raise misfire recall. *Happened:* misfire recall reached 16/16 and fault recall 0.86 with no change in false alarms — the only configuration meeting both criteria. *Learned:* the weights moved some errors from misfire to knock. *Stability:* over 10 random seeds, Experiment 2 beat the baseline every time (mean fault recall 0.85 ± 0.02 vs 0.77 ± 0.03, both with ≈ 0.20 false alarms), so the gain is real; but it met *both* criteria in only 2 of 10 seeds, and the baseline run in Table 1 was a favourable seed.

Experiment 3 — no synthetic knocks in training. *Expected:* if synthetic knocks teach the real knock sound, removing them should hurt real-knock recall. *Happened:* real-knock recall *rose* (0.84 ⟶ 0.93) while synthetic-knock recall collapsed (0.67 ⟶ 0.42). *Learned:* the synthetic clips did not teach the real knock sound — but since every real knock comes from AudioSet, high real-knock recall may partly reflect recognising AudioSet audio.

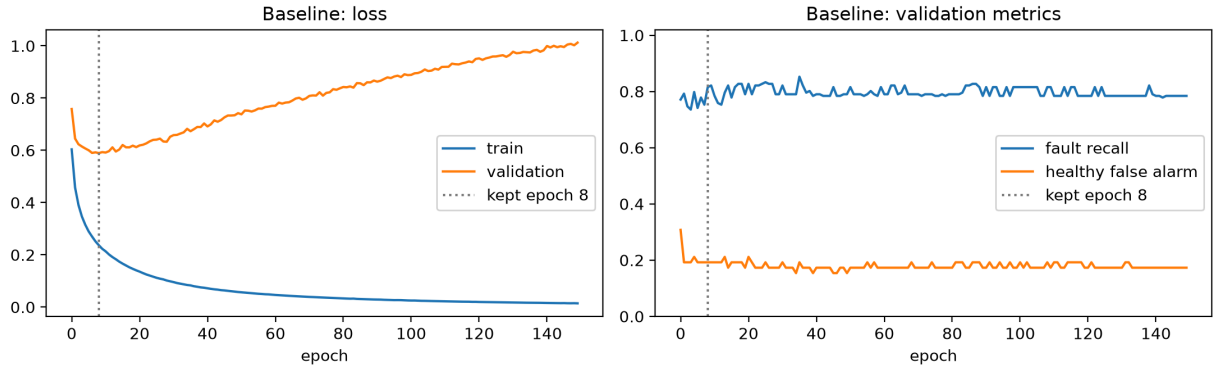
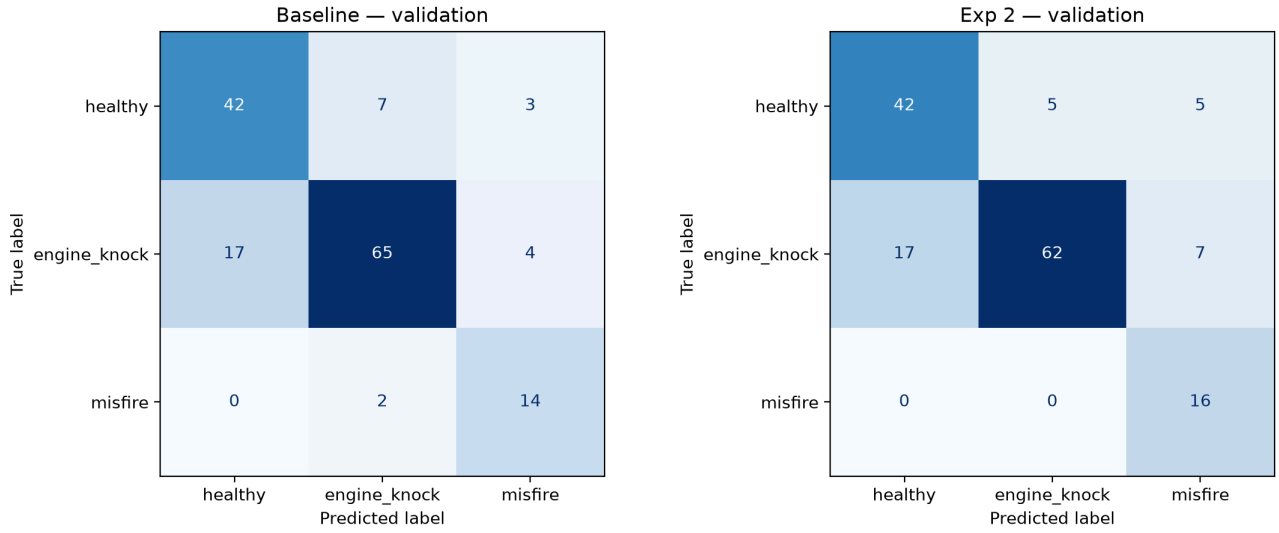


Figure 1: Baseline training curves. Left: loss; right: validation fault recall and false-alarm rate. The dotted line marks the epoch kept.

5. Evaluation

5.1. How well does it perform?

The best configuration on validation (Experiment 2) catches 86 % of faults and flags 19 % of healthy engines (Figure 2). Inference takes ≈ 0.6–0.8 s per clip on a laptop CPU (40 ms on GPU), meeting the operational constraint; the classifier adds negligible cost.



(a) Baseline (b) Experiment 2

Figure 2: Validation confusion matrices (rows: true class; columns: predicted).

Final test (run once). We selected Experiment 2 on validation (higher mean fault recall across seeds). On the 154 held-out test clips it reached **fault recall 0.91** with a **0.11 false-alarm rate**: knock recall 0.81 (real 0.90, synthetic 0.72) and misfire 16/16. On `real_test` it caught 33 of 38 real knocks (0.87). Both business criteria are met on test, but the baseline scored almost the same there (0.90 / 0.11), and the test split shares the dataset's source structure, so these numbers do not show how the model would do on a fleet's own recordings. For scale, a production system trained on ~45,000 vehicles recorded with one fixed device reports an audio-only ROC AUC of 0.80 for knock-type noise [8]; our higher figures from a few hundred clips should be read as optimistic.

5.2. Where does it fail?

Of 33 baseline validation errors, 13 are synthetic knocks predicted as healthy. Three representative cases (**TODO:** listen to each clip and describe what is audible):

1. `revix_car_knocking_0043` — **knock predicted healthy with 97 % confidence.** A 4.1 s synthetic clip. Short knock clips (< 5 s) are misclassified 55 % of the time (6 of 11) versus 20 % for longer ones; AST pads short clips with silence, leaving fewer knock events to detect. *Consequence:* a confidently missed fault — the costly error.
2. `audioset_9wGJydlJvrk_30000` — **a real knock predicted healthy (95 %).** Real-world recordings vary in microphone, distance and background noise; with a single source of real knocks the model has little variety to learn from. *Consequence:* the failure mode most relevant to deployment.
3. `hf_healthy_059` — **healthy predicted misfire (92 %).** Healthy and misfire clips from this source share recording conditions, so the model must rely on subtle differences in engine rhythm. *Consequence:* an unnecessary inspection — cheaper, but repeated false alarms reduce trust.

Because a missed fault costs far more than a false alarm, we favour configurations with higher fault recall even at a slightly higher false-alarm rate, and recommend reporting a confidence score so borderline cases can be reviewed.

5.3. Is the model hearing the fault, or the source?

A linear probe on the same AST features identifies a clip's source with **95 %** accuracy (chance 54 %), and **98 %** among healthy clips alone. We ran three further checks (notebook Section 9):

Table 2: ROC AUC when the recording source is held fixed (0.5 = chance).

Model	Knock vs healthy (Revix only)	Misfire vs healthy (HF only)
Baseline	0.87	0.86
Exp 2 (class weights)	0.87	0.89
Exp 3 (no synthetic)	0.70	0.78

- **Within-source tests (Table 2):** comparing clips from the *same* source, the model still separates faulty from healthy well (AUC ≈ 0.87–0.89). The features carry real fault information — with the caveat that the Revix "knocks" are overlaid sounds and the misfire test has only 28 clips.
- **Zero-shot baselines:** CLAP [5], an audio–text model used with no training, scores below the benchmark (fault recall 0.22), confirming that off-the-shelf models do not know engine faults. AST's own "Engine knocking" output detects AudioSet knocks far better than synthetic ones (AUC 0.86 vs 0.62), consistent with AST having seen these clips during pre-training.
- **Source-adversarial training:** we trained the representation to hide the source within each class [6]. The adversary was partly fooled, but a fresh probe still identified healthy-clip sources **perfectly** at every setting (Figure 3), a known weakness of adversarial removal [7]. The source fingerprint cannot be trained away.
- **Transfer across sources:** a knock detector trained only on AudioSet knocks vs Hugging Face healthy clips scores AUC 0.42 on Revix knocks vs Revix healthy clips — no better than chance — and equalising every clip's average spectrum did not change this (`recording_fingerprint.ipynb`).

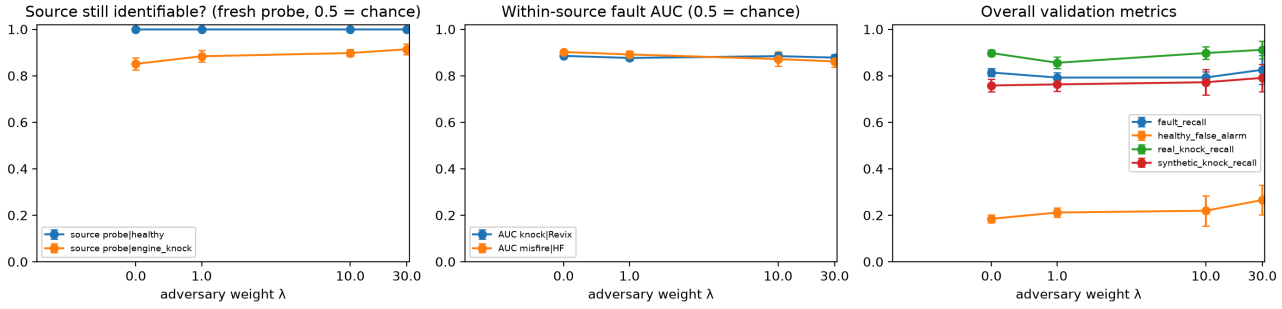


Figure 3: Source-adversarial training (5 seeds per setting). Left: source still identifiable by a fresh probe; middle: within-source fault AUC; right: overall validation metrics.

6. An unsuccessful experiment: partial fine-tuning

1. **Why we expected improvement.** AudioSet features are generic ("engine", "vehicle"); training the top layers should specialise them to engine faults, a standard way to improve transfer learning.
2. **What happened.** Fault recall stayed flat (0.82 → 0.81) and false alarms rose slightly (0.19 → 0.21), at ~6,000× more trainable parameters (14.2 M), minutes instead of seconds of training, and a 345 MB model to deploy.
3. **Evidence.** Validation loss bottomed out at epoch 2 while training loss kept falling, a sign of rapid overfitting. Knock recall rose but misfire fell from 14/16 to 12/16: the model improved on the class with the most training data (399 knocks) at the expense of the smallest (76 misfires).
4. **What we learned.** With ~700 clips, more model capacity mainly fits the majority class; the bottleneck is data, not model flexibility.
5. **Effect on our recommendation.** We prefer the frozen model: equally accurate on our primary metric, far cheaper to train, store and update.

7. Recommendation: continue development (not yet a pilot)

The approach is promising: a frozen pre-trained model with a tiny classifier meets the business criterion on the test split (Experiment 2), runs in under a second on a laptop CPU, and still separates faults from healthy engines when the recording source is held fixed. **We do not recommend a pilot yet**, because:

- We cannot rule out that much of the performance comes from recognising the recording source; even adversarial training could not remove it.
- All misfire examples come from one source, and no test set measures false alarms on real knocks.
- Results are close to the criteria rather than clear of them: only 2 of 10 seeds met both on validation.

Next step (≈ 4–6 weeks): collect the fleet's own recordings — same phone, position and routine for every vehicle, healthy and faulty, as in [8] — labelled by each vehicle's OBD-II misfire counters and by mechanics, including recordings before and after repairs. Record the phone's accelerometer too: in [8] vibration detected rough-running engines better than audio. Retrain the frozen model on this data and run a **shadow pilot**: the tool flags vehicles, but inspections proceed as usual, so its hit rate and false-alarm rate can be measured at no risk. Proceed to a limited pilot if it catches ≥ 85 % of confirmed faults with ≤ 20 % false alarms on the fleet's own vehicles.

8. References

1. Y. Gong, Y.-A. Chung, J. Glass. "AST: Audio Spectrogram Transformer." *Interspeech*, 2021.
2. J. F. Gemmeke et al. "Audio Set: An ontology and human-labeled dataset for audio events." *ICASSP*, 2017.
3. S. Chen et al. "BEATs: Audio Pre-Training with Acoustic Tokenizers." *ICML*, 2023.
4. KweriMoto Engine Sounds dataset. Hugging Face: `rayyyyy007/kwerimoto-engine-sounds`.
5. Y. Wu et al. "Large-scale Contrastive Language-Audio Pretraining with Feature Fusion and Keyword-to-Caption Augmentation." *ICASSP*, 2023.
6. Y. Ganin et al. "Domain-Adversarial Training of Neural Networks." *JMLR*, 2016.
7. Y. Elazar, Y. Goldberg. "Adversarial Removal of Demographic Attributes from Text Data." *EMNLP*, 2018.
8. D. Fedorishin et al. "Large-Scale Acoustic Automobile Fault Detection: Diagnosing Engines Through Sound." *KDD*, 2022.